

family to take his place. It was a measure of Badal's political savvy, that there was not even a murmur of dissent in Akali quarters over the elevation. In fact, the second-rung leaders, having long taken it as a fait accompli, vied with each other in unanimously endorsing Badal junior's name for the top post. And, the sycophantic tone of an avalanche of congratulatory advertisements and statements in the vernacular newspapers by the rank and file hailing the Akali supremo for putting Sukhbir at the helm only underscored the total sway that the Badal family has on the party and power. (see *Badal Inc.*)

It was left to the Opposition Congress and the breakaway Akali leaders to take swipes at the handover. While Leader of the Opposition and former Congress chief minister Rajinder Kaur Bhattal snidely dubbed it as "an internal affair of the Badal family", the splinter Akali factions slammed the chief minister for "unabashedly promoting dynastic politics"—a charge Sukhbir stoutly denies. "I am not a parachute president," he avers, adding, "Having led the party from the front, it's a hard-earned honour."

RAVI S SAHNI



SUKHBIR HAS EMERGED AS THE DEFINING FACE OF GENNEXT AKALIS, PANTHIC BY LINEAGE, MODERN IN OUTLOOK AND ONE WHO APPROACHES POLITICS WITH CORPORATE SAVVY.

HIGHFLYER: Sukhbir and his matching Pajeros

By formalising Sukhbir's new role, the party has lent legitimacy to his well-orchestrated and over-arching role as a prime mover in the SAD-BJP coalition Government. Also, it marks a generational shift in SAD, a party likened to an old-age home because of the preponderance of grey-bearded, rustic 'jathedars' in it moulded by the 'morcha' (agitational) politics of the past. Sukhbir has emerged as the defining face of GenNext Akalis, which is Panthic by lineage, modern in outlook and corporate in practice. And, owner of a Rs 500-crore hospitality venture in Gurgaon, he openly flaunts his jet-set lifestyle: he vacations at exotic resorts abroad, gyrates to DJs at parties in his posh residence in Chandigarh, and regularly pops up at exclusive corporate dos in Delhi.

Ironically, he owes much of his dramatic ascent to his bête noire Amarinder Singh who, as the Congress chief minister, targeted the Badal family with the Vigilance Bureau slapping corruption cases against them. Despite being a two time MP, till 2002 Sukhbir was still in his father's political shadow and showed little interest in state politics until Amarinder unleashed his Akali-centric politics of vendetta.

Sukhbir was pitch-forked into playing street-fighter and rapidly emerged as the lynchpin in the party's comeback campaign in the 2007 Assembly elections. He was largely credited with steering the SAD-BJP combine to victory—extracting sweet revenge on Amarinder who had once dismissed him as 'baloongra' (kitten).

The kitten soon turned into a tiger, but not without some carefully orchestrated help from papa. When he was made the party's working president last year in recognition of his stellar role in the elections, senior Akali leaders acquiesced meekly. They had little choice, having bargained for tickets for their own kin in the Assembly elections as a tacit quid pro quo for accepting Sukhbir's ascendancy, all part of Badal's well-crafted strategy to buttress his son's credentials as his successor. Sukhbir's elevation as the full-fledged president, in part, is meant to legitimise his overarching role and blunt any criticism about his being an extra-constitutional authority.

Not surprisingly, he looms large in the SAD-BJP Government. Reckoned as the real power hub, the Sukhbir-stamp is evident in all spheres of governance—from postings and transfers of top bureaucracy to scripting the development priorities of the state and even playing trouble-shooter—as he had done during the Sikh-Sacha Sauda flare-up last year by cutting short his holiday abroad.

While Badal has been tacitly promoting Sukhbir's role as an agenda setter for the Government, BJP is feeling anything but pleased. In fact, the junior coalition partner had taken umbrage at Sukhbir calling the shots—even in the BJP-helmed ministries prompting the BJP high command to